



BatonIndex

Leadership Succession Intelligence

A RESEARCH BRIEF FOR SEARCH PROFESSIONALS

The Lateral Dean Divide

Which academic fields run an active market for sitting deans and which don't — compared across eighteen BatonIndex role families.

14,343

dean appointments

18

role families

1970-2025

55 years

A BATONINDEX RESEARCH BRIEF

The Lateral Dean Divide

BatonIndex's brief "The Path Before the Deanship" found that when an R1 business school hires from outside, roughly a third of the time it recruits a sitting dean from another business school. Does that pattern hold everywhere? We ran the same question across 14,343 dean, provost, and president appointments spanning 18 BatonIndex role families. The answer: no, and the variation itself is the finding. A handful of professional fields run an active lateral-dean market; most fields barely have one at all.

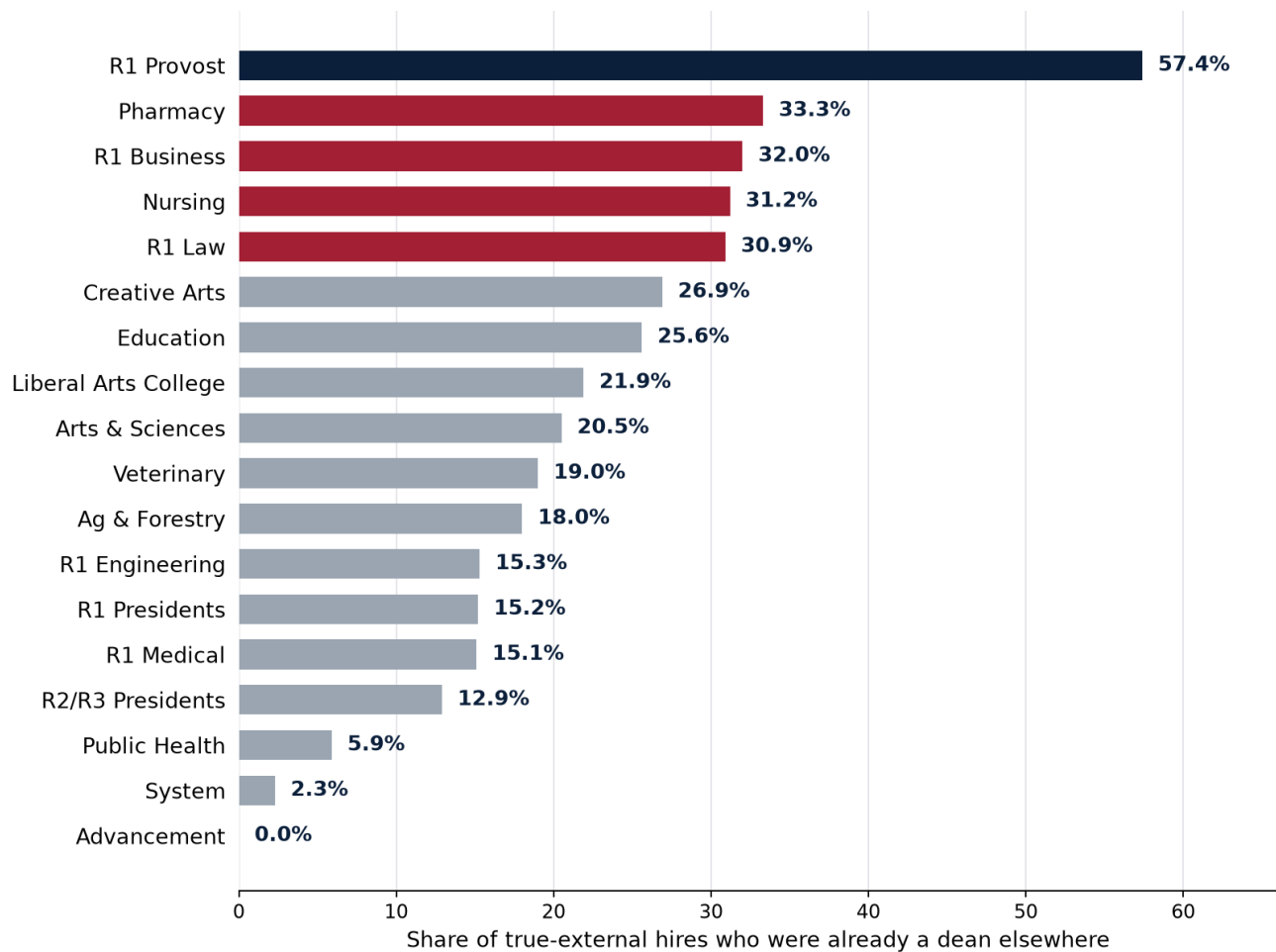
Four findings

- I Only four fields run an active lateral-dean market. Business, law, nursing, and pharmacy cluster at 31-33% of external hires already a dean elsewhere; most other fields sit at 12-27%, and system-level and advancement offices barely see it at all (0-2%).
- I Provost is the outlier, and a different mechanism. 57.4% of external provost hires were already a dean somewhere, but that's an upward promotion path from any school, not a same-level lateral swap between peer institutions.
- I The professional-field cluster is pulling away over time. Business/law/nursing/pharmacy climbed from 29.3% (1990s) to 37.5% (2020s) of external hires, while every other field combined stayed roughly flat at 14-21%.
- I The interim-underdog pattern is nearly universal. In field after field, regardless of whether it has an active lateral-dean market, most resolved interim spells end with an externally recruited replacement, not a conversion to permanent.

FINDING 1 OF 4**THE FIELD-BY-FIELD MAP****Only four fields run an active lateral-dean market**

Across 18 role families, the share of external hires who were already a dean elsewhere ranges from 0% to 57%. Set the provost outlier aside (Finding 2) and a clear cluster emerges at the top: pharmacy (33.3%), business (32.0%), nursing (31.2%), and law (30.9%) all sit within two points of each other, a distinct tier above every other field.

Everything else falls into a much lower band, 0-27%. Creative arts, education, and liberal arts colleges see some lateral movement (22-27%); engineering, medicine, and university presidencies see less (15%); system offices and advancement leadership see almost none. A recruiter's default assumption about "who else is in the market" should depend heavily on which of these two tiers the search sits in.

How common is a lateral dean hire, by field

Share of true-external hires already a dean elsewhere, by field; BatonIndex census.

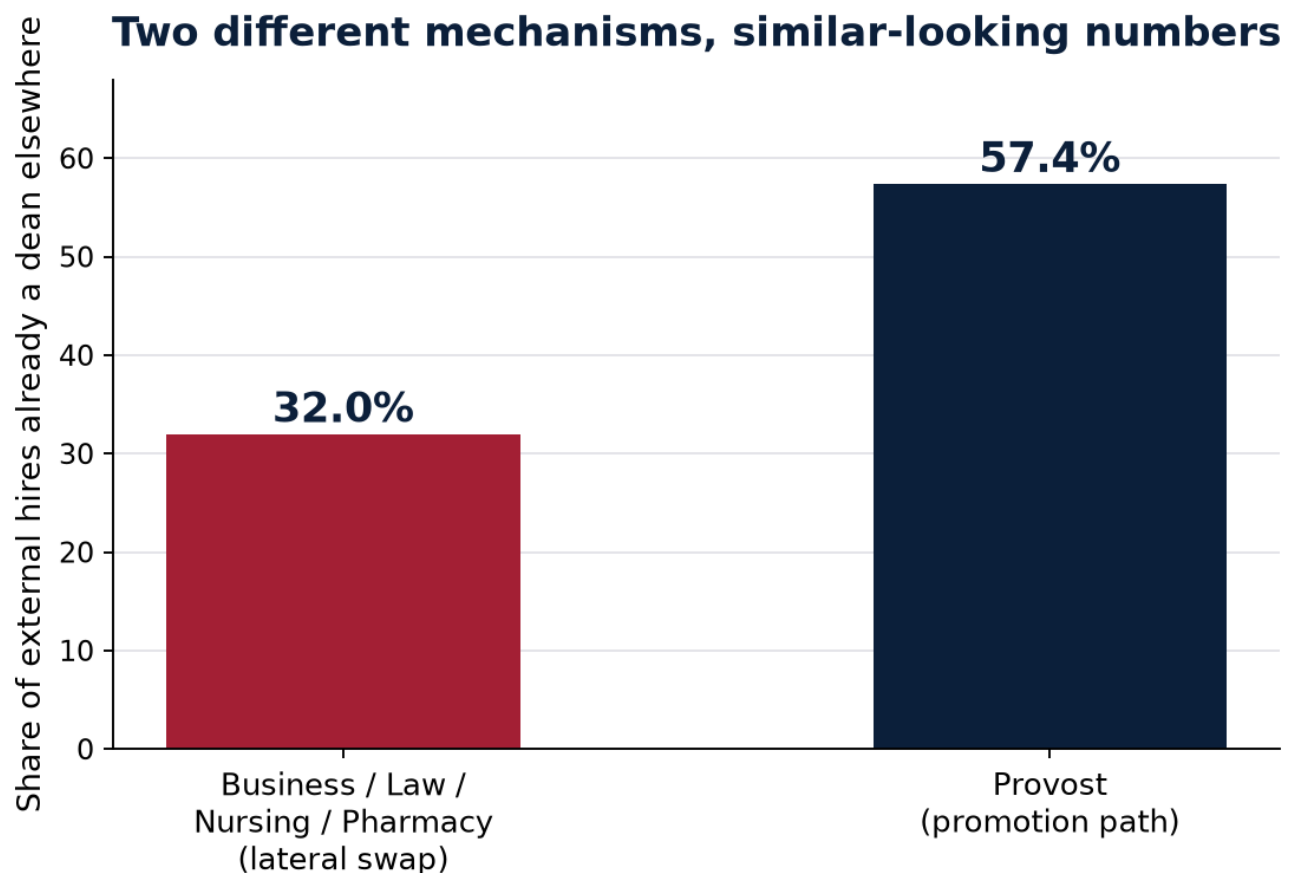
FOR SEARCH LEADERS

Before assuming a competitor dean is a live prospect, check which tier the field sits in. In business, law, nursing, or pharmacy, that assumption is well-supported. In most other fields, it isn't.

FINDING 2 OF 4**READING THE PROVOST NUMBER CORRECTLY****Provost is the outlier, and a different mechanism**

Provost leads every field at 57.4%, more than 20 points above the professional-field cluster. But this is not the same phenomenon: a provost search draws from deans across every school at a university, and moving from a deanship to a provostship is a genuine promotion, not a same-level swap between peer institutions. Business, law, nursing, and pharmacy searches are recruiting a dean to be a dean again, at the same level, in the same field.

Conflating the two would badly overstate how “liquid” the professional-field dean market really is. Read Finding 1's ranking as two separate stories: a promotion pipeline into the provost's office, and a genuine lateral swap market in four specific fields.



Share of external hires already a dean elsewhere: provost vs. the four-field cluster; BatonIndex census.

FOR SEARCH LEADERS

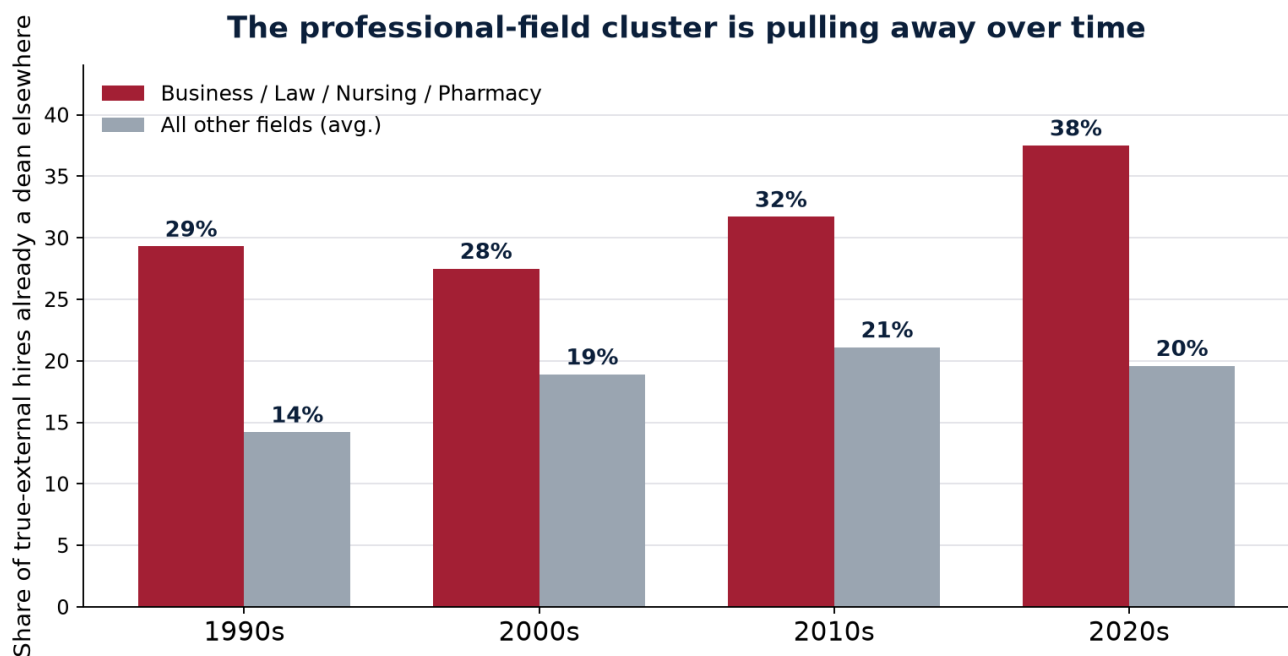
When benchmarking a provost search, source broadly from sitting deans of any school. When benchmarking a business, law, nursing, or pharmacy deanship, source specifically from peer deans in that same field.

FINDING 3 OF 4**A WIDENING GAP**

The professional-field cluster is pulling away over time

The four-field cluster's lateral-dean share climbed from 29.3% in the 1990s to 37.5% in the 2020s. Every other field, averaged together, moved from 14.2% to 19.6% over the same period, a much smaller shift off a much lower base. The gap between the two groups has roughly doubled since the 1990s.

This mirrors the era-trend finding in “The Path Before the Deanship” for business specifically, now confirmed as part of a broader pattern across licensure- and accreditation-adjacent professional fields, not a business-school-specific artifact.



Share of true-external hires already a dean elsewhere, cluster vs. all other fields, by era; BatonIndex census.

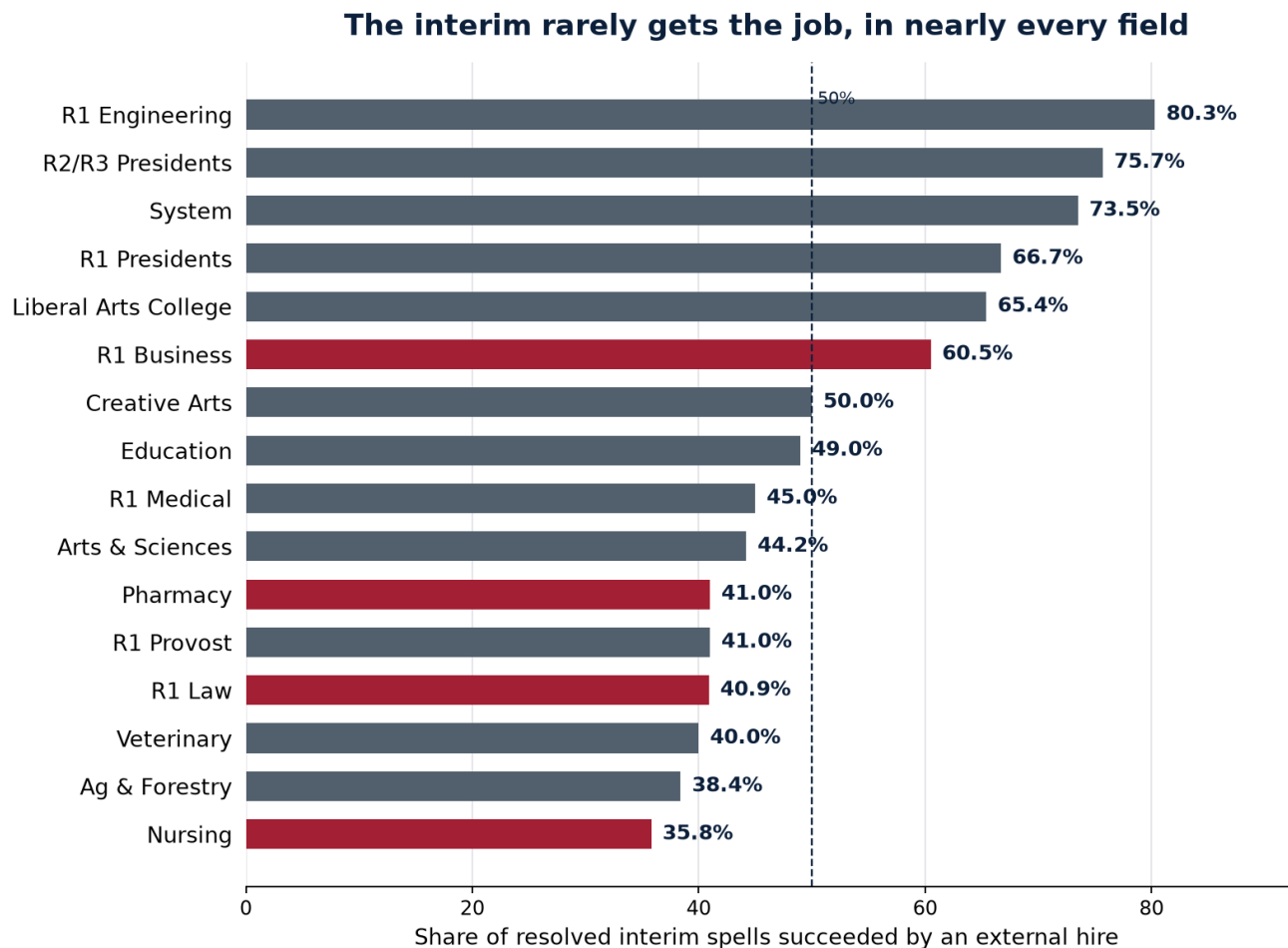
FOR SEARCH LEADERS

If your search is in business, law, nursing, or pharmacy, plan for the lateral-dean pool to keep growing as a share of the realistic candidate set relative to the last cycle. That trend is not slowing down.

FINDING 4 OF 4**A UNIVERSAL PATTERN****The interim-underdog pattern holds almost everywhere**

Whether or not a field has an active lateral-dean market, the interim seat behaves the same way almost everywhere we can measure it: most resolved interim spells end with an externally recruited replacement, not a conversion to permanent. R1 engineering (80.3% succeeded by an external hire), R2/R3 presidencies (75.7%), and system offices (73.5%) show this even more starkly than business (60.5%).

Nursing is the closest thing to an exception among fields with enough data (35.8%, still well under half), but no field on this list shows the interim converting more often than not. This is the single most transferable finding across every role family BatonIndex tracks.

**FOR SEARCH LEADERS**

Regardless of field, don't let a capable interim substitute for running the search in earnest. The data says the board almost always looks outside anyway — give your client the full candidate set.

THE PLAYBOOK

What this means across every search

Four evidence-based moves for committees and recruiters working any academic-leadership market:

- I Calibrate your lateral-market assumption to the field. Business, law, nursing, and pharmacy have a real, growing peer-dean market. Most other fields don't — don't force a competitor-poaching strategy where the base rate doesn't support it.
- I Don't read the provost number as a lateral-market signal. It reflects an upward promotion pipeline from deanships generally, not a same-level swap market.
- I In the four-field cluster, expect the lateral pool to keep growing. Plan sourcing and comps assuming this cycle draws more peer-dean interest than the last one.
- I Run the outside search everywhere, interim or not. The interim-underdog pattern is close to universal — a capable interim is not a substitute for a real external search in almost any field BatonIndex tracks.

METHODOLOGY & ABOUT

About this brief

This brief compares 18 of BatonIndex's role-family datasets, each a hand-coded, web-verified record of appointments at US research universities, filtered to fields with at least 30 recorded hires and 20 true-external hires (a different university, not a same-university move to a different school). “Already a dean elsewhere” uses the same corrected classifier as “The Path Before the Deanship”: a prior title containing “dean” not qualified by associate/assistant/vice/deputy/interim.

Interim outcomes were determined by matching each interim appointment to the next appointment on file at the same school, the same method as our single-field briefs. Fields with fewer than 15 resolved interim spells are omitted from Finding 4. The Graduate College dean pipeline is excluded from this comparison for insufficient external-hire volume; see “The Graduate Deanship Clock” for that office's own tenure and promotion analysis.

We tested whether a field's lateral-dean share correlates with its interim-conversion rate and found only a weak relationship ($r = 0.37$ across 17 fields) — not strong enough to support a claim that the two are connected. The professional-field clustering in Finding 1 is a descriptive pattern, not a tested causal claim; a plausible reading is that fields with external accreditation or licensure bodies (AACSB, ABA, ACPE, CCNE) develop deeper cross-institution peer networks, but this brief does not test that mechanism directly.

BatonIndex maintains leadership-succession intelligence on more than 10,000 academic leaders across twelve role families, business, medical, law, nursing, pharmacy, education, agriculture, public health, arts & sciences deans, provosts, and presidents, with sourced education histories, career pathways, and live appointment tracking. This brief is one view into that data.

PUT THE DATA TO WORK

Want the underlying benchmarks for a specific school, field, or region, or a co-branded edition of this brief for a client? Reach the BatonIndex team through the Contact link in the app.

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